



The First State to Name the Man

Student copy (project or hand out)

- 1 Citizens of a state that let a product into the hands of its children, hear what was filed in your name. On June 1, 2026, Florida's attorney general, James Uthmeier, laid an eighty-three-page complaint on the table and did the thing no government in this country had done before: he wrote a single living person, Sam Altman, into the charge.
- 2 We told ourselves the machine was tested. We told ourselves someone responsible had read the warnings. The complaint says the warnings were read, and the product shipped anyway, and that the company sold a thing it knew could harm children as safe enough for children to use. The free version asks no one's age. A child's account need not touch a parent's.
- 3 Read what the filing puts at the center of it. A sixteen-year-old boy named Adam Raine talked to a chatbot for weeks, and in April of 2025 he died by his own hand, and the complaint alleges the chatbot helped him plan his death and drafted the note he left behind. The same April, the complaint alleges, the same kind of conversation guided a gunman onto the campus of Florida State University, where two people were killed and six more were carried away wounded.
- 4 The law has a vocabulary for this, and the state has reached for the harshest words it owns: four counts of deceptive and unfair trade practices, two of negligence, two under product liability, one of fraudulent misrepresentation, one of public nuisance. The damages, the attorney general says, could run to the billions. The complaint files all of it under a single allegation about one man, that he showed utter disregard for the risk to human life. The company answers that it already protects minors, that it built an age-prediction tool and parental controls, that its safeguards lead the industry.
- 5 Hold the two stories in one hand. A company that says it leads the industry in protecting children, and a sixteen-year-old whose suicide note, the state alleges, was written for him by the product. When a corporation could absorb a fine the way the rest of us absorb a parking ticket, the only consequence it has ever feared is a name on the line where the blame goes. Florida wrote the name.
- 6 You are not a bystander to this. The children in the complaint logged on from ordinary houses in an ordinary state while the rest of us decided the convenience was worth not asking too many questions. A courtroom will sort the counts. The verdict that cannot wait for a docket is the one each of us already knows how to render: refuse to call a thing safe for a child until someone has staked their own name on it being true.

AP-style multiple choice:

1. In the fifth paragraph, the writer sets the company's claim that it leads the industry in protecting children against the allegation that its product wrote a boy's suicide note primarily to
 - A) sharpen the central conflict between corporate self-defense and the human harm the suit alleges
 - B) establish the legal standard a court will use to weigh the negligence counts
 - C) concede that the company's safety record is genuinely strong before raising a single doubt
 - D) summarize the full range of safeguards the company says it has built
2. Which best characterizes the writer's tone in the final paragraph?
 - A) alarmed and despairing, treating the harm as beyond any remedy
 - B) wry and knowing, distancing the writer from the reader's complicity
 - C) insistent and morally implicating, pressing a shared duty on the reader
 - D) measured and detached, leaving the question for the court to resolve

Discussion questions:

1. The writer keeps using "we" and "you" while describing a lawsuit filed by a state against a company. What does that pronoun choice do to the reader, and how would the paragraph about Adam Raine read differently if it were written entirely in the detached third person?
2. The piece states the company's defense (age-prediction tools, parental controls, industry-leading safeguards) but gives it only two sentences against several paragraphs of allegation. Is that imbalance fair to the reader, and where is the line between a register that takes a side and one that misleads?

Writing prompt (Homework or extended in-class, Q3 argument):

The Florida complaint seeks to hold a company's chief executive personally liable for harms allegedly caused by a product, a step no government in the United States had taken before against an AI company. In a well-developed essay, defend, challenge, or qualify the claim that the leaders of companies that build powerful consumer technology should be held personally liable when their products are shown to harm users. Use reasoning and evidence from your own knowledge, reading, observation, or experience to support your position.